also a sea route, first through Tonkin and then to Canton, that connected directly from peninsular India. The presence of Indian temples as far east as the Fujian coast opposite Taiwan underlines how pervasive our contacts were with China.

This deep cultural association is reflected vividly in key cultural sites of China such as the Dunhuang Caves or the White Horse Temple in Luoyang. The tradition of contacts naturally had human expressions – from those like the monks Kasyapamatanga and Dharmaraksha who brought scriptures to Luoyang, to Kumarajiva who introduced many Buddhist texts into Chinese, and Dammo/Bodhidharma who is associated with the Shaolin tradition. That the two most famous Chinese travellers through history – Fa Xian and Xuan Zang – both came to India speaks of its salient place in ancient China. The trade of that period has been the subject of extensive research and it could comfort some that it had a different balancing problem. It is said that by the sixth century, Indian music was supposedly so popular that an imperial edict sought briefly to ban it. To those who argue that there is a long tradition of productive contacts and beneficial coexistence, the record certainly backs it up. But how the cultures may have influenced each other historically has receded completely from the popular narrative.

On the Indian side, neither public sentiment about China nor awareness of these links was particularly strong. And the advocates of bonding were, in any case, rare voices. Part of that may be due to an oral tradition that kept little record of interface with others. It could equally be a reflection of a more self-centred society for whom those who left were inconsequential, and those who came but marginal. This Indian attitude towards China stands in contrast to much of the world and one not easy for the Chinese to comprehend. Today, with the popularity of Indian films or the promotion of tourism, there is the possibility of drawing on this phase of ties.

The near past initially held out some hope, expressed by the great scholar P.C. Bagchi,* that the experiences of the Second World War would bring together the two peoples who had almost forgotten their common past. Interestingly, the Chinese elite after 1949 was quite conversant with this history with India. It was telling that Chairman Mao himself reminded the Indian Ambassador in 1950 of a popular saying that Chinese who do good